Extension of Application – ISO/IEC 17025 Activities

In addition to proficiency testing and certified reference material activities, this procedure shall also apply to complaints and/or appeals arising from testing, calibration, sampling, reporting of results, and customer service activities conducted under ISO/IEC 17025 accreditation.

This includes, but is not limited to, complaints or appeals relating to:

- Test or calibration results
- Sampling activities
- Method selection or application
- Report content or interpretation
- Turnaround times
- Staff conduct or competence
- Alleged nonconformities with ISO/IEC 17025 requirements

Upon receipt of a valid complaint, the laboratory shall open a non-conformance and record it on the NC register. An initial risk evaluation must be performed to determine if the complaint is an isolated case or a systematic failure. When sending an acknowledgement of the complaint, it must include the NC number. An investigation must be carried out, aligning with the requirements of procedure 7.10 non-conforming work. In alignment with the laboratory's performance-based model(7.10) the NC shall be monitored over a demarcated period. If no recurrence of the issue is observed during the monitoring period, the risk is deemed low, and the NC shall be closed without further action. However, if a recurrence is observed, a formal risk assessment must be conducted immediately to determine the systematic impact.

Additional Responsibilities (ISO/IEC 17025 Context)

Laboratory Manager:

- Ensures compliance with ISO/IEC 17025 clauses 7.9 (Complaints), 7.10 (Nonconforming Work), and 8.5 (Actions to Address Risks and Opportunities).
- Ensures records of complaints and appeals are maintained and retrievable.

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Technical Manager/ Laboratory Supervisor:

- Provides technical input into investigations relating to test/calibration validity.
- Confirms whether reported results may be affected and determines the need for result recall or re-issue.

Additional Procedure – ISO/IEC 17025 Complaints and Appeals Handling

1. Receipt and Logging

❖ All complaints and/or appeals relating to ISO/IEC 17025 laboratory activities shall be received in writing and recorded in the complaints register.

❖ The complainant shall be informed of receipt of the complaint and the process to be followed.

2. Review and Classification

❖ The Laboratory Manager/Supervisor shall confirm whether the complaint or appeal relates to:
a) PT/CRM activities, or
b) ISO/IEC 17025 testing, calibration, or sampling activities.

❖ Where related to ISO/IEC 17025, the matter shall also be evaluated as potential nonconforming work.

3. Investigation

❖ An investigator independent of the activity being complained about shall be appointed where practicable.

❖ Evidence shall be collected, including but not limited to:

- Test/calibration records
- Instrument logs and calibration status
- Method validation/verification records
- Environmental monitoring records
- Staff training and competence records

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- Customer communications

4. Technical Impact Assessment

- The Technical Manager shall assess whether the validity of reported results is affected.
- Where results are found to be invalid or questionable:
  - The customer shall be notified in writing.
  - Amended or withdrawn reports shall be issued where required.
  - Re-testing or re-sampling shall be considered where feasible.

5. Decision and Corrective Action

- The Laboratory Manager/Supervisor shall determine whether the complaint or appeal is valid.
- Root cause analysis shall be performed where applicable.
- Corrective and/or preventive actions shall be documented and implemented in accordance with the corrective action procedure.

6. Communication of Outcome

- The official outcome of the investigation shall be communicated to the complainant in writing.
- Where applicable, this shall include:
  - Explanation of findings
  - Actions taken
  - Any impact on previously reported results

7. Impartiality and Confidentiality

- All complaints and appeals shall be handled impartially and without discrimination.
- Personnel involved in the original activity shall not decide on the outcome of the complaint where resources allow.

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- Confidentiality of the complainant and related records shall be maintained.

8. Risk-Based Thinking

- Complaints and appeals related to ISO/IEC 17025 activities shall be reviewed for potential risks to result validity, customer confidence, and accreditation compliance.
- Identified risks shall be logged in the risk register and managed in accordance with the risk management procedure.

Records (ISO/IEC 17025 Context)

The following records shall be retained:

- Complaint/appeal register entries
- Investigation reports
- Corrective action records
- Customer communications
- Revised or withdrawn test/calibration reports (if applicable)

All records shall be controlled in accordance with the document and record control procedure.

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AzurESky "ensure quality of test"	**COMPLAINT AND APPEALS HANDLING PROCEDURE**	
	Document no: ASMF 7.18B	
	Compiled by: **Sifiso Nyambi - Laboratory Manager**	
	Approved by: **Nonhlanhla Msibi - Operations Manager**	

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01	Addition of a paragraph which links the procedure to 7.10 non-conforming work procedure.	Fundamental procedure alignment to solve complaints	05/05/2026

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Effective date	Rev status	Next review date
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